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Groups

Pool A

India
Japan
China
Kazakhstan

Pool B

Malaysia
Korea
Bangladesh
Chinese Taipei



pressure and lost decision-making sharpness was concerning. Tactical tweaks unsettled the balance, exposing defensive gaps against top-tier opponents. “We struggled to hold a consistent defensive shape, particularly when we committed players forward on the attack. We took some risks with new strategies; they didn’t always pay off, but the lessons we learned will be crucial for the tournament ahead,” admitted captain Harmanpreet Singh, who missed five matches with a finger injury.

Penalty corner puzzle

Harmanpreet’s (pic, above) absence cost India more than its best defender; it also robbed the team of its most lethal drag-flicker. Though he still managed six Pro League goals to

Rankings

Country	World	Asia
India	7	1
Malaysia	12	2
Republic of Korea	13	3
Japan	18	5
China	23	6
Bangladesh	29	9
Chinese Taipei	38	13
Kazakhstan	81	16

happened in the five games we played against Australia before the Olympics, and we defeated them in Paris. There is a reason we play the best teams so that we can become better.”

Experience under strain

India had one of the most seasoned squads in the Pro League: only three of 24 players had fewer than 50 caps, while 14 had over 100. That such a unit buckled under